

Fewer notices, or fewer illegalities?

A public claim, tested against twenty years of annual reports

THE CLAIM

“We had times when we issued over 1,000 enforcement notices per year.”

Johann Buttigieg, Planning Authority CEO, The Malta Independent, 7 September 2025

Now around 200, which he attributed to there being fewer illegalities.

The Authority's own reports: it issues notices “only where contraveners are uncooperative”.

VERDICT

MISLEADING

*Accurate figures,
incomplete explanation.*

SUPPORTED

LARGELY
SUPPORTED

NOT
SUBSTANTIATED

MISLEADING

CONTRADICTED

MAIN RESULTS

1,033

Then: over 1,000 a year

Average notices a year 2001–2009 (MEPA). The figure is right.

187

Now: around 200

Average 2020–2024 (Planning Authority reports). Also right: notices fell 82%.

~2,860

Complaints stayed high

A year on average in 2017–2024: more than in 2009 (2,701) or 2011 (2,105).

~1,200

Still confirmed illegal

Complaints confirmed as illegal in 2024, close to 2018 (~1,280).

7–13

Notices per 100 cases

Of complaints confirmed as illegal, 2018–2024. Most end in removal or an application to legalise.

FAIR TO SAY

The chief executive also said the Authority has struggled with enforcement. Persuading owners first is a recognised approach, and most notices now carry daily fines. This check is about what fewer notices can show.

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

☐ Complaints and outcomes for 2012–2016.

☐ Any survey showing illegal building has fallen.

☐ How many cases end in a sanctioning permit.

☐ The yearly source of 1,500 direct actions.